INFORMATION TO KEEP WITH YOU

My complete treatment handbook

Oral etoposide · Days 1–3 twice daily

Understand your treatment. Know what to expect. Keep your plan to hand.

Displayed calendar
21 days
See the active treatment phase

Treatment stages
2
Explained in the treatment reference

Regimen source
NCCP 00388
Version 4

Take your prescribed etoposide capsules twice daily on Days 1–3. Days 4–21 have no planned etoposide. The source cycle is 21 days; continue only while helping and tolerable, after team review.

Treatment stages

01 **Chemotherapy course**
Review each cycle

02 **Review and next plan**
Individual plan

Your team confirms the active stage and dates. The full treatment guide explains each step.

Inside your handbook

		PAGE
01	Understanding your treatment	2
02	Your schedule, tests and appointments	4
03	Symptoms and supportive care	7
04	Sources and further information	11

My name _____

Hospital / oncology team _____

Use the urgent instructions and contact numbers in your treatment guide. Your team must replace example numbers before patient use. Your individual treatment plan takes precedence.

SACTCHECK · CHAPTER 01

Understanding your treatment

Oral etoposide · Days 1–3 twice daily · National Cancer Control Programme (NCCP) 00388

When to get help

Emergency: call 112 / 999

Severe breathing difficulty, collapse, seizure or severe chest pain: call emergency services. Do not wait for an online answer.

Contact your oncology service immediately

Temperature 37.5°C or higher, 36°C or lower, shivering or suddenly feeling unwell — even with a normal temperature. Call oncology immediately for fever or suddenly feeling unwell, unusual bleeding, severe tummy pain, persistent vomiting or diarrhoea, or new cough or breathlessness. Do not wait for the next cycle.

Follow the urgent contact instructions from your treating hospital. If you cannot reach the team, seek urgent medical assessment. Outside clinic hours, use your instructed out-of-hours pathway or the emergency department.

This page does not diagnose symptoms or decide whether it is safe to stay at home. You do not need to know which medicine caused a symptom before calling.

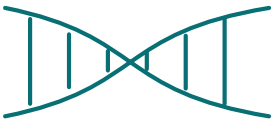
Your chemotherapy

This treatment aims to slow or shrink extensive small-cell lung cancer when intravenous or combination chemotherapy is unsuitable. Benefit varies; your team explains the aim for you.

TOPOISOMERASE-II INHIBITOR CHEMOTHERAPY

Etoposide capsules

Supplied brand may vary



Disrupts deoxyribonucleic acid (the cell's genetic material) (DNA) copying and repair

Etoposide interferes with topoisomerase II, an enzyme involved in DNA structure and repair. DNA damage can stop cancer cells dividing. Healthy blood-forming and other cells can also be affected. Absorption by mouth varies, so oral and intravenous doses are not interchangeable.

Medicine reaches cells → DNA damage persists → Cell division disrupted

What to watch for

Call oncology immediately for fever or suddenly feeling unwell, unusual bleeding, severe tummy pain, persistent vomiting or diarrhoea, or new cough or breathlessness. Do not wait for the next cycle.

The drawings are simplified explanations of drug action, not anatomical pictures or a prediction of response.

My treatment

Evidence and limits

Older studies reported tumour responses with oral etoposide. The evidence is limited, and the different oral schedules cannot be assumed to have the same benefit or risks. A small uncontrolled study of a 21-day oral course does not establish a survival advantage or validate all three NCCP schedules. Its participants had recurrent cancer and substantial treatment toxicity; do not transfer its response percentage to an individual.

SACTCHECK · CHAPTER 02

Your schedule, tests and appointments

Oral etoposide · Days 1–3 twice daily · NCCP 00388

Your treatment course

Treatment stages

01 **Chemotherapy course**
Review each cycle

02 **Review and next plan**
Individual plan

Your team confirms the active stage and dates. The full treatment guide explains each step.

This shows treatment timing, not guaranteed symptom-free days. Your team confirms the active phase and dates.

REVIEW EACH CYCLE

Chemotherapy course

Cycle | Review

Take your prescribed etoposide capsules twice daily on Days 1–3. Days 4–21 have no planned etoposide. The source cycle is 21 days; continue only while helping and tolerable, after team review.

INDIVIDUAL PLAN

Review and next plan

Review

Your team reviews benefit and side effects and agrees whether to continue, change or stop.

Relative educational plan; your team confirms actual appointments and changes.

BASELINE → TREATMENT → FOLLOW-UP

My tests and checks

Check	Before treatment	During the cycle	Before next course	After treatment
Safety blood tests	Blood count, kidney and liver profile	Extra tests if needed; oral etoposide regular dates confirmed by team	Blood count, kidney and liver review	Follow abnormal results as advised

Check	Before treatment	During the cycle	Before next course	After treatment
Disease assessment	Confirm treatment aim	Symptoms reviewed	Scans or other tests on consultant plan	Agree next treatment or follow-up

The team arranges and reviews tests. This guide shows expected timing; it does not record completed appointments. NCCP 00388 v4 · official regimen

THE WHOLE TREATMENT JOURNEY

Oral etoposide · Days 1–3 twice daily: treatment and checks

Extensive small-cell lung cancer (SCLC) · Days 1–3 twice daily

Take your prescribed etoposide capsules twice daily on Days 1–3. Days 4–21 have no planned etoposide. The source cycle is 21 days; continue only while helping and tolerable, after team review.

Read from left to right. Columns show stages, not equal lengths of time. This is a general plan: no dates or personal information are needed. Your team confirms which steps apply and arranges appointments.

Treatment, tests and reviews across the course

Care / check	Before treatment	Treatment days	Between courses	Course review
Treatment NCCP 00388	Confirm capsule strength, number, dosing days, storage and contact numbers with the pharmacist.	Take your prescribed etoposide capsules twice daily on Days 1–3. Days 4–21 have no planned etoposide. The source cycle is 21 days; continue only while helping and tolerable, after team review.	Follow support plan and report symptoms	Review benefit/ toxicity; next plan
Safety tests NCCP 00388	Blood count, kidney/liver tests	Review symptoms; extra tests if needed	Blood count, kidney and liver tests before treatment and regularly at team-specified intervals. Scans and follow-up follow the consultant plan.	Follow abnormal results

What each check is for

1 **Before each course**

Before starting

Safety and plan may change

Ask / **act:** Team confirms next treatment

At the next review, ask

- Which treatment phase am I in, and what happens next?
- Which test is expected next, who arranges it, and who explains the result?
- Who should I contact if an expected appointment has not arrived?

This map does not show whether a test has been ordered, booked or completed. Do not wait for a scheduled test if you develop new symptoms.

Practical treatment planning

Agree the arrangements with your oncology team.

STEP 1

Before treatment

Confirm capsule strength, number, dosing days, storage and contact numbers with the pharmacist.

STEP 2

Treatment visit or home course

Take etoposide capsules on an empty stomach using the exact prescribed dose and days. Do not open, chew or crush them. Capsule strengths, quantities and storage follow the supplied pharmacy label. Oral and intravenous doses are not interchangeable.

STEP 3

Bring to review

Bring your medicine list, dose record and questions; report new symptoms before starting another course.

Symptoms and supportive care

Oral etoposide · Days 1–3 twice daily · NCCP 00388

Your 21-day cycle.

Timing is a general guide; symptoms may start or stop at other times.

Treatment or check	Timing in this view
Prescribed capsules	 **Days 1–3** intravenous (IV)
No planned chemotherapy	 **Days 4–21** Blood-count and symptom recovery varies.

Effects vary; no risk curve or guaranteed recovery day is shown.

The next cycle starts 21 days after this one, if your team confirms it.

> Do not use this page to calculate or change doses.

Between-treatment notes

Day 1–3: Treatment days

Take your prescribed etoposide capsules twice daily on Days 1–3. Days 4–21 have no planned etoposide. The source cycle is 21 days; continue only while helping and tolerable, after team review. Follow the confirmed prescription; report problems promptly.

Day 4–21: Between treatments

No planned chemotherapy; continue prescribed support and monitoring. Do not restart until the team confirms the next cycle.

Support around the medicines

1 Sickness and bowel symptoms

Use your prescribed prevention or rescue medicine. Report persistent vomiting, diarrhoea or inability to drink; fever with severe tummy pain needs urgent assessment.

2 Blood tests and review

Blood count, kidney and liver tests are checked before treatment and regularly on dates set by your team for the selected schedule.

3 Pregnancy, fertility and medicines

Discuss fertility and contraception before treatment. Tell the team about pregnancy, breastfeeding, all medicines, supplements and vaccines. Check before changing any medicine.

4 Missed or vomited capsules

Do not double a missed dose or take replacement capsules after vomiting without team advice. Record what happened, contact the oncology pharmacist/team, and follow the next scheduled dose in the agreed plan.

5 Safe handling

Take etoposide capsules on an empty stomach using the exact prescribed dose and days. Do not open, chew or crush them. Capsule strengths, quantities and storage follow the supplied pharmacy label. Oral and intravenous doses are not interchangeable. Keep away from children; ask the pharmacy how to return unused or damaged capsules.

Between treatments

Keep your prescription and contact plan to hand.

Blood tests and review

Pregnancy, fertility and medicines

When to call

Blood counts

An infection can be serious even after treatment days have finished. A normal earlier blood test does not rule out a new problem.

Tests and review

Blood count, kidney and liver tests before treatment and regularly at team-specified intervals. Scans and follow-up follow the consultant plan.

Scans and tumour markers

Your consultant decides which are relevant and when. Do not assume a fixed imaging interval or that tumour markers are required for everyone.

After treatment

Agree follow-up, symptom support and the next plan before the course ends.

Questions worth asking

Why can treatment be delayed?

Blood results or symptoms may make a delay or dose change safer. Your team confirms when to restart.

Are capsules gentler than an infusion?

No. Oral chemotherapy can cause serious toxicity and needs blood tests and review. Oral and intravenous doses cannot be exchanged.

When will I have scans?

Your consultant sets the timing for your disease and treatment plan. No universal scan or tumour-marker interval is specified here.

> **Try explaining the plan back:** Explain which days you take treatment, when your next blood tests are due and whom you will call tonight if unwell.

Check your exact treatment This guide covers only Days 1–3 twice daily. Do not combine it with another etoposide schedule.

Supportive prescription draft for review. This is a regimen template. It is not an issued patient prescription; individual review and completion are required.

Oral etoposide Days 1–3 twice daily support

Active medicines: etoposide

Emetogenic risk: low

Medicine	Dose / route	When
Individually prescribed sickness medicine	As prescribed under oral low-risk guidance	As required; persistent symptoms need review No duplicated preventive courses. Product interactions and patient factors apply.

Additional phase-specific support

- Follow a written prescription with start/stop days.
- No routine premedication required; local policy applies.
- Review diarrhoea, hydration and capsule handling.

Before signing: verify allergies, current medicines, interactions, renal / hepatic function, QT risk, sedation, prior response, total steroid exposure and the rescue-medicine duration. Do not duplicate medicines from another phase.

Individual changes / rescue duration: _____
Prescriber / date: _____ Pharmacy review: _____

What to watch for

You do not need to know which medicine caused a symptom before calling.

1 Hair / energy

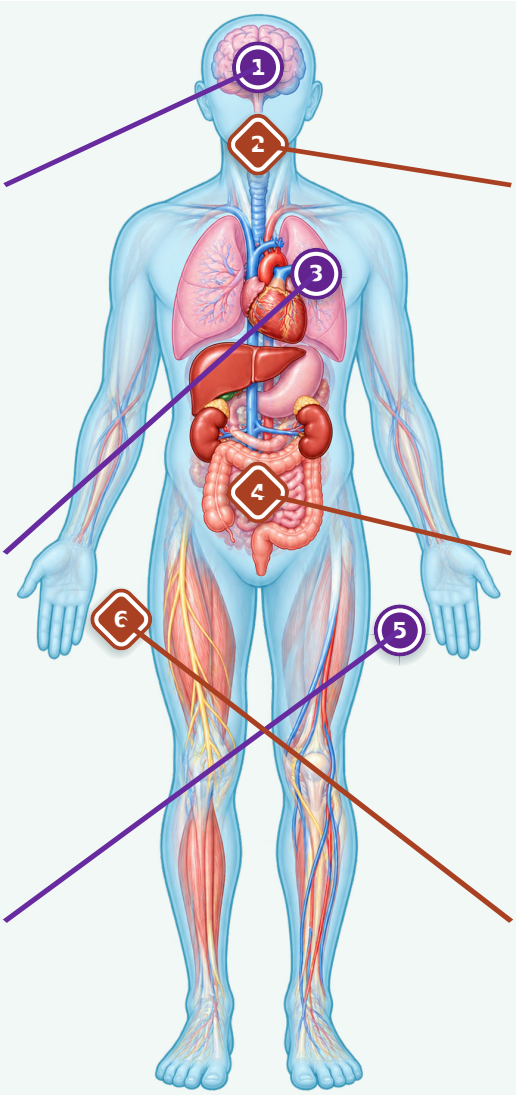
Etoposide

Hair loss and tiredness may occur; report marked weakness or dizziness.

2 Mouth

Etoposide

Tell the team about ulcers or painful swallowing; ask for help if you cannot drink.



3 Chest / breathing

Etoposide

New cough, breathlessness or chest pain needs urgent assessment.

4 Stomach / bowel

Etoposide

Report persistent diarrhoea or vomiting. Fever with severe tummy pain is urgent.

5 Skin / allergy

Etoposide

Report spreading rash; swelling or breathing difficulty needs immediate help.

6 Blood counts

Etoposide

Fever, unusual bruising or bleeding needs an immediate call. The marker is schematic.

Selected effects, not every possible effect or a prediction. Blood-count, skin and line markers are schematic. Number and text carry meaning; colour is decorative.

Call oncology immediately for fever or suddenly feeling unwell, unusual bleeding, severe tummy pain, persistent vomiting or diarrhoea, or new cough or breathlessness. Do not wait for the next cycle.

When to get help

Call 112 / 999 for severe breathing difficulty, severe chest pain, collapse or a seizure.

Call oncology immediately: temperature 37.5°C or above, 36°C or below, shivering or suddenly feeling unwell, even with a normal temperature. Follow your hospital's temperature instructions. If you cannot reach the team, seek urgent medical assessment. Do not wait for the next appointment.

Oncology daytime: 087 12345678 · **Out of hours:** 087 87654321

EXAMPLE ONLY — team must replace both numbers before patient use.

SACTCHECK · CHAPTER 04

Sources and further information

Oral etoposide · Days 1–3 twice daily · National Cancer Control Programme (NCCP) 00388

Use this information alongside the plan agreed with your treatment team. Your team confirms your medicines, doses and appointments.

1. **NCCP 00388 v4 · pNCCP 00388 supportive care; NCCP antiemetic guidance**
   https://healthservice.hse.ie/documents/6911/388_oral_etoposide_.pdf
2. **HPRA Vepesid product information**
   https://assets.hpra.ie/products/Human/30580/Licence_PA2239-006-001_27022024163103.pdf
3. **NCCP NCIS medical oncology antiemetic guidance V8**
   https://healthservice.hse.ie/documents/7180/Supportive_Care_Antiemetics_for_inclusion_NCIS_Medical_Oncology.pdf
4. **Johnson 1990 oral etoposide phase II study**
   https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/2170589/